

Weather system fuels tornadoes, wildfires and dust storms across U.S.



BUTCH DILL/AP

People carry a safe away from a destroyed building after a tornado passed through Plantersville, Alabama. More than 80 tornadoes had formed across eight states since Friday as a deadly storm system that also spawned dust storms and sparked wildfires in Oklahoma and Texas pushed toward the East Coast on Sunday. **Story, A2**

Trump loyalist’s VOA plans are thrown into limbo

BY SARAH ELLISON, YVONNE WINGETT SANCHEZ AND AARON SCHAFER

During his first term, President Donald Trump accused Voice of America of speaking “for America’s adversaries — not its citizens.” Over the weekend, he essentially dismantled it. Late Friday, Trump issued an executive order that directed VOA and an array of federal offices to “be eliminated to the maximum extent consistent with applicable law.” About 1,000 journalists were placed on indefinite leave. Those who showed up to work to broadcast their programs were locked out of the building.

Kari Lake said she would transform an outlet that’s now all but shut down

It wasn’t exactly what Kari Lake was planning. The onetime candidate for Arizona governor and U.S. Senate whom Trump tapped to lead VOA had, like other MAGA loyalists, eagerly sought a role in the new administration. An ardent booster of Trump’s false claims that the 2020 election was stolen, Lake had also echoed Trump’s criticism of national media outlets

and of the content at VOA. If confirmed to lead the organization, she had said, she would be able to transform the outlet into a powerful “weapon” to fight an “information war.” But the rapid pace of events in recent days shows that Trump’s campaign to dismantle the federal bureaucracy and control U.S.-backed news content around the globe has effectively gutted VOA, potentially forcing it to go dark for the first time since it launched during World War II. It also reveals the uncertainty facing the people Trump installed to lead federal agencies — and the tension between their ambitions to be relevant and his own desire

to cut those agencies out of existence. People like Lake. Voice of America delivers news coverage to countries around the world where a free press is threatened or nonexistent. At its start, VOA told stories about democracy to people in Nazi Germany. VOA and affiliates such as Radio Free Europe and Radio Free Asia are designed as a form of soft diplomacy, a way to tout the United States’ free-press values in countries where antidemocratic forces prevail. Trump and his allies have attacked the federally run news outlet in the same way they have

SEE VOA ON A4

Wartime power used to deport some migrants

OFFICIAL SAYS 137 REMOVED UNDER 1798 ACT

Administration questions court ruling blocking flights

BY MARIANNE LEVINE, MARIA SACCHETTI, JOYCE SOHYUN LEE AND NATALIE ALLISON

More than half of the 261 immigrants expelled to El Salvador on Saturday were swept out of the United States using a wartime powers act, a White House official said Sunday, amid questions about whether the Trump administration flouted a judge’s order barring use of the statute to hasten deportations. President Donald Trump secretly signed a proclamation Friday invoking the Alien Enemies Act of 1798, saying he would quickly remove Venezuelans aged 14 and over who allegedly belong to the transnational gang Tren de

Aragua. Since then, 137 people were dispatched to the Central American nation via the proclamation, according to the White House official, who spoke on the condition of anonymity to discuss the Trump administration’s enforcement strategy. The rest were removed under other federal laws, including 23 people from El Salvador with ties to the MS-13 gang and 101 additional Venezuelans, the official said. U.S. District Judge James Boasberg on Saturday temporarily blocked Trump from using the act to remove immigrants without a hearing and instructed officials to return any airplanes carrying them to the United States. He

SEE TRUMP ON A8

Migrant couple arrested despite protected status

Venezuelans taken from family’s D.C. home while their children watched

BY TEO ARMUS, MARIA SACCHETTI AND STEVE THOMPSON

The Venezuelan couple — exhausted after a six-week journey north through an unforgiving jungle and gritty cities — waded across the southern border in Texas with their three children in 2022, part of a historic wave of migrants seeking refuge from economic and political turmoil who are now seeing the ground shift beneath them in the United States. The couple, whom The Washington Post is identifying only by

their middle names Cesar and Norelia, and their three children were allowed into the country by Border Patrol. Later, the Department of Homeland Security granted them temporary protected status — a legal promise of security against being deported to the country they fled. They settled in a D.C. neighborhood with their children — ages 4, 9 and 13 — received Social Security numbers, a driver’s license for Cesar and new jobs cleaning hotels. They gave immigration officials their address. Then last Monday, every legal safeguard they thought was in place was seemingly upended. With two of their children looking on, screaming and crying, Border Patrol arrested the couple in D.C., removing them from their home in handcuffs on a misdemeanor charge of illegally crossing the border more than two years ago.

SEE COUPLE ON A7

Some tourists drop plans for U.S. travel, citing Trump

BY ABHA BHATTARAI

International travelers concerned about President Donald Trump’s trade policies and bellicose rhetoric have been canceling trips to the United States, depriving the U.S. tourism industry of billions of dollars at a time when the economy has started to appear wobbly. Canadians are skipping trips to Disney World and music festivals. Europeans are eschewing U.S. national parks, and Chinese travelers are vacationing in Australia instead. International travel to the United States is expected to slide by 5 percent this year, contributing to a \$64 billion shortfall for the travel industry, according to Tourism Economics. The research firm had originally forecast a 9 percent increase in foreign travel, but revised its estimate late last month to reflect “polarizing Trump Administration policies and rhetoric.”

SEE TOURISM ON A10

Without Medicaid, ‘I would lose everything’

In a Kentucky county that voted for Trump, some fear cuts to aid that gave them back their lives



ALLISON JOYCE/FOR THE WASHINGTON POST

Candice Fee, 42, in her room at a recovery house in Harlan County, Kentucky, on Friday.

BY CLEVE R. WOOTSON JR.

HARLAN, KY. — Candice Fee isn’t sure who’s right in the debate over the future of Medicaid: the Republican president whose party says it will leave federal health funding intact as it seeks to slice billions in government spending or the Democrats who warn that the broad cuts the president has promised can’t happen without carving into one of the government’s most costly programs. But if Medicaid is axed, Fee knows exactly what will happen to the life she has pieced back together after decades of addiction. “If it were to go away today, I would be homeless tomorrow. I would lose everything. All my counseling, all my treatment. I would absolutely be homeless tomorrow,” said Fee, 42, who has lived in Harlan all her life, most of it spent in a cycle of addiction and rehabilitation. A Medicaid-funded treatment program she entered last year has her feeling, for the first time, optimistic about not living a life dominated by substance abuse. In group meetings, she and

SEE KENTUCKY ON A16

Sole survivor of 2005 crash finds purpose in all the pain

BY MICHAEL LARIS

When his eyes opened under the surface of the Potomac River, Jonathan Godfrey saw blurry darkness. He fought the intense urge to inhale. He was still strapped in his cockpit seat, now on the bottom of the muddy river. He didn’t know how he got there, only that he had to get himself free. If I don’t get a breath, I’m going to die, he thought. Two decades before 67 people died in a collision between an Army Black Hawk and an American Airlines regional jet over the Potomac River near Reagan National Airport, a medical evacuation helicopter plunged into those same waters. Three people were on it: Godfrey, who was a flight nurse; Nicole Kielar, a young paramedic who had recently applied to medical school and went almost everywhere with her dogs, Murphy and Sydney; and pilot Joseph E.

SEE SURVIVOR ON A2

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